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Seeley rocks No. 1 Loyola

► District 13-C Blackhawks pull biggest upset of season

By CLAYTON JONES
of the Missourian

Seeley-Swan basketball fans were dancing on air after Pat Morin rebounded Brian Riebe's missed jumper to clinch the District 13-C Blackhawks' stunning 86-84 upset over Missoula Loyola Friday at the Ram activity center.

They had a right to be ecstatic. They'd just come out of nowhere to topple Montana's No. 1-ranked Class B team, handing Loyola its first loss after 11 straight wins.

But veteran Seeley coach Kim Haines remained calm. After all, he'd been through this kind of thing before.

"We did it to Loyola once before," said Haines, who has coached the Blackhawks for three decades. "They were unbeaten and we knocked them right out of the state tournament."

Haines paused to reflect when how long ago that happened. "I don't know," he said. "It must have been about 50 years ago."

Actually, it was 1973, when Seeley upset Loyola at the divisional tournament.

Seeley-Swan pulled off the win by attacking Loyola's fierce fullcourt pressure for a multitude of high-percentage shots in the first half, trailing only 46-44.

Then, when the Rams tried to pull in the reins and force it into a halfcourt game, Seeley responded by bombing home six 3-pointers.

But for all that, the Loyola powerhouse remained in the game until the very end when John Giuliani rallied the Running Rams from a four-point deficit to a one-point lead in the last 50 seconds. Giuliani hit a 3-pointer, Loyola's first of the game, then followed up a missed shot by Riebe after a steal to put Loyola ahead 84-83 with 35 seconds left.

It was Loyola first lead of the fourth quarter.

But the Blackhawks, who had watched their confidence grow throughout the contest, weren't about to have victory stolen away. They kept their composure and worked the ball around the perimeter until they found Jesse Boone along the baseline. Boone drove to the basket and scored what proved to be the winning field goal with 12 seconds remaining.

Reibe's final shot fell short. Morin rebounded and was fouled, then made 1 of 2 free throws to give the Blackhawks their final two-point edge.

Until Seeley's sudden 3-point barrage, Loyola appeared to have taken control of the game in the third period behind the inside scoring of 6-foot-4 senior Damon Gordon. Gordon, who sat out the final three minutes of the first half after picking up his third foul, came out determined to control the tempo after intermission. He hit 4-of-5 shots in the quarter as Loyola took a 60-51 lead.

But the Blackhawks had spent the whole game refusing to go away and this time was no different. With Mike Larson's two 3-pointers leading the way, Seeley outscored Loyola 12-2 in the final three minutes of the third quarter to assume a 63-62 lead going into the final stanza.

"Our confidence just kept growing," Haines said. You could see it on the Blackhawks' faces. It was as though they suddenly realized they could win.

And you could see it on the Rams' faces too. Every now and then there was a sudden look of panic, where before, especially early in the game, they exuded nothing but confidence.

After consecutive 3-pointers by Abe Kats, Morin and Matt Schneiter, Seeley found itself with a 74-63 lead with five minutes to go.

But the Rams wouldn't quit. They slapped the fullcourt pressure back on and Seeley, now with the lead, was more reluctant to attack the Ram press with the gusto it had in the first half.

Loyola abandoned its strategy of working it inside to Gordon and fought back primarily on the one-on-one play of Riebe. He scored eight straight points to set up the memorable finale. The Rams were aided when Seeley lost point guard Schneiter, who fouled out with 3:46 left.

Seeley, which has no senior starters, was at a disadvantage in terms of experience, size, strength and athletic ability. But in the final analysis, the Blackhawks won because their far superior outside shooting was enough to overcome Loyola's huge 7-22 edge in turnovers, and because they were able to fight the Rams to a 41-41 standstill on the boards.

Riebe led the Rams with 28 points, but his 11-for-33 shooting from the floor typified Loyola's miserable outside shooting throughout the game. The Rams were at their best when they went inside to Gordon — who hit 8 of 17 shots — but that was a strategy they found hard to stick with because of his frequent foul trouble, caused mostly by pushoffs on offensive rebound attempts.

Boone's inside play was far more consistent for Seeley. He finished with 29 points and 12 rebounds and was complemented by Larson's inside-outside 23-point performance and 14 points from Schneiter on 6-of-7 shooting.

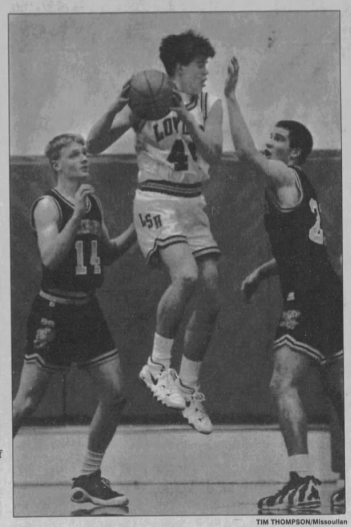
Seeley raised its mark to 8-7 and became a sudden force to be reckoned with in District 13-C play.

Seeley-Swan	23	21	19	23	– 86
Loyola	23	23	16	22	– 84

LOYOLA (7-0, 11-1) — Brian Riebe 11-33 (6-8) 28, Scott Welch 5-14 (6-6) 17, John Giuliani 3-3 (0-0) 7, Damon Gordon 8-17 (5-9) 21, Rick Hyland 2-8 (3-6). . Totals: 30-76 (22-29) 84.

SEELEY-SWAN (8-7, 8-7) — Pat Morin 3-14 (1-2) 8, Abe Kats 5-12 (1-2) 12, Matt Schneiter 6-7 (0-0) 14, Jesse Boone 8-12 (13-16) 29, Mike Larson 7-14 (6-8) 23. Totals: 29-59 (21-29) 86.

3-point goals—Seeley-Swan 7 (Larson 3, Schneiter 2, Morin, Kats), Loyola 1 (Welch). Total fouls—Loyola 23, Seeley-Swan 20. Fouled out—Schneiter. Rebounds—Loyola 41 (Riebe 13), Seeley-Swan 41 (Boone 12). Turnovers—Loyola 7, Seeley-Swan 22.



TIM THOMPSON/Missoulian

Missoula Loyola's Rick Hyland, center, beats out Seeley-Swan defenders Pat Morin, left, and Matt Schneiter for a rebound during their game Saturday night.

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